Website Testing & Evaluation Report

Envisioning Climate Futures

Testing Setup (Device)

- Windows (with Chrome, Edge)
- iOS (with Safari)

Overview

Overall, the website communicates its goals and content reasonably well. The core ideas and background information are clearly presented, allowing users to understand what the project is about. However, key messages are sometimes difficult to identify due to the amount of text and lack of emphasis, making it harder for users to quickly grasp the most important points.

From a usability and navigation perspective, the site performs well. Navigation is intuitive, and users are generally able to move through pages without getting stuck or feeling lost. The structure supports a logical flow, especially within example sections.

In terms of cross-platform performance, the site is mostly stable, but there are a few instances where spacing and resizing behave awkwardly, particularly on smaller screens. These issues can affect readability and overall user experience.

Overall, the website provides good communication and a solid user experience. Improvements can be made by restructuring content to be more concise, ensuring that relevant information is clearly placed and linked, and making key messages stand out more effectively. Providing more immediate visual impressions and maintaining consistent styling across pages would further enhance clarity. Additionally, mobile/small screen layouts require more attention to enhance readability and interaction.

More detailed strength, issues, and specific suggestions are outlined below.

Strength

- Effective use of images, videos, and links helps break up long text sections, making the content more engaging and less overwhelming to read.
- Text is often organized with bullet points, which improves readability and makes key messages easier to scan and understand quickly.
- The navigation tabs within example pages are intuitive and create a natural flow between sections. They guide the user through the content in a logical order and reinforce a clear reading progression.

Areas for Improvement

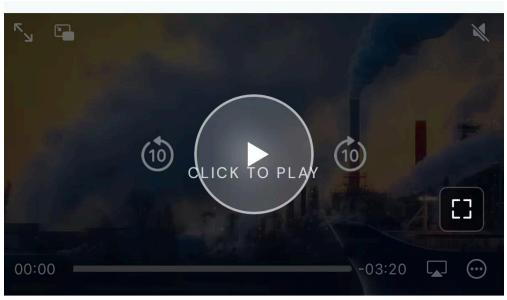
1. **Large Plain Text Chunks**
    - Some pages contain too much text, particularly in sections such as *Methodology*, *Modelling and Visualizing Flood* (*Future Projection),* and *Climate and Weather*.

- Large, uninterrupted text blocks without supporting visuals make it harder for readers to process content quickly and to grasp key information or relevance.
- During the think-aloud session, the participant often felt unsure about why certain information was important or how it connected to the overall purpose of the site.
- Consider breaking these sections into shorter segments and incorporating more visuals, highlights, or summaries to improve clarity and engagement.

2. **Home -> Video**
    - The video is quite long; during think-aloud, the participant played it at 2x speed.
    - It takes up a large portion of the screen, making it difficult for users to immediately understand where they are upon landing.
    - Video as a format requires time commitment and may not be ideal as the first element users interact with despite its ability to convey the overall story well.
    - **Suggestion**: Consider rearranging the elements so that a direct first impression can be delivered immediately when the website is launched.

3. **Home -> Video Full screen button**
    - There are two fullscreen buttons. On desktop, one appears disabled, while on mobile both function.

Web



Mobile

- This is a slight UI inconsistency; it might be better to use a single, consistent control.
- **Suggestion**: Standardize a single full screen button and ensure that the experience is consistent between desktop and mobile.

4. **Home -> Challenge and Approach (Format)**
    - Section headers are too small relative to body text, even with accent color.
    - On larger screens, headers become the least readable element on the page, and most of the visual attention is drawn to the bolded paragraph.
    - **Suggestion**: Increase header size and visual hierarchy to better guide users through the content.

5. **Home -> Challenge and Approach (Transition)**

- The Challenge and Approach text section have fade-in transitions on launch of the page. Depending on the screen display (if the sections are not in the screen when first launched), the transition may be ineffective as it is triggered before the user can see this.
- **Suggestion**: Trigger the animation when the section enters the viewport instead of on load, or remove/reduce the animation to ensure it meaningfully enhances visibility.

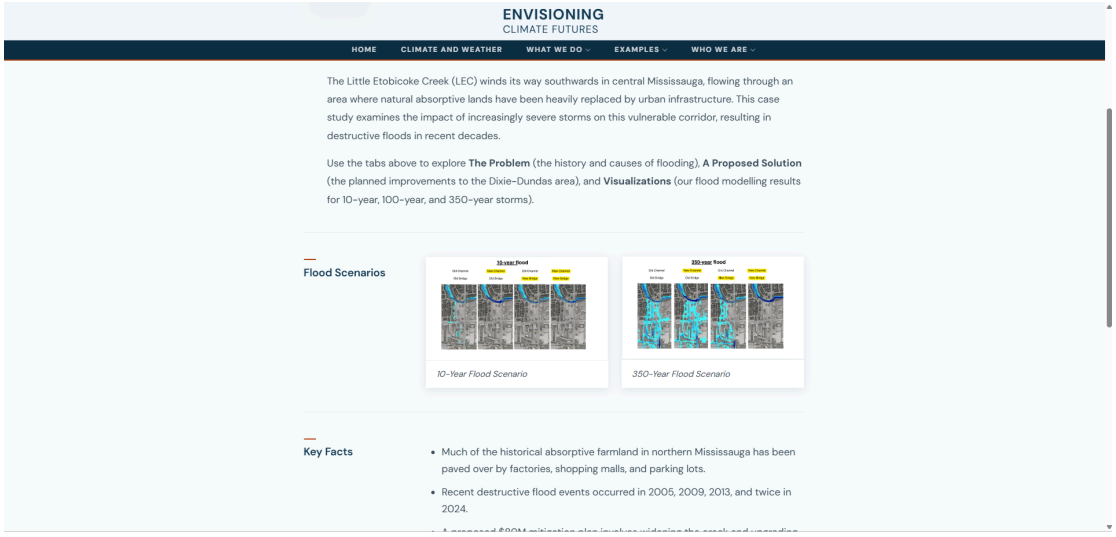
6. **Climate and Weather -> Links and citation**
    - Images lack clear source attribution, making it difficult to assess credibility.
    - Links below images have no explanation of their purpose or relevance.
    - For example, content from Carbon Brief is used, but attribution should include a direct article link rather than just the homepage (according to the website, “credited ‘Carbon Brief’ with a link to the article”).
    - The purpose of the World Weather Attribution remains unclear.
    - **Suggestion***:* Correct citation. Add clear captions with source attribution and short descriptions explaining each link’s relevance.

7. **Climate and Weather -> Media interactivity**
    - The image appears to be a screenshot of an interactive element (e.g., “choose a country”), which creates an expectation of interactivity.
    - During think-aloud, the participant was disappointed that interaction was not supported.
    - **Suggestion***:* Embedding the interactive element here might be hard to achieve. Clearly linking users to the original source to explore it can be helpful too.

8. **What We Do -> Tab name readability**
    - Tab names such as “Modelling and Visualizing Floods/Wildfires” are long and hard to distinguish at a glance. This makes quick navigation and comparison difficult.
    - **Suggestion***:* Simplify naming (e.g., one main tab “Model and Visualization” with subtabs “Floods”, “Wildfires”) to improve readability and clarity.

9. **Don River Example -> BEFP Mention**
    - BEFP is mentioned at the end of the visualization page but relates more to project scope limitations.
    - Its placement may confuse users about its relevance to the visualization.
    - **Suggestion***:* May be better to move this discussion to the “Proposed Solution”.

10. **Little Etobicoke Example -> 4x1 Images**
    - The 4x1 images used under Little Etobicoke Creek’s overview and visualization are too small, making embedded text difficult to read across devices.



- No zoom or interaction is provided (have to do right click -> open image in new tab if user wishes to take a closer look), limiting usability.
- **Suggestion***:* Increase image size or add zoom/expand functionality for better accessibility.

11. Little Etobicoke Example -> Problem -> News articles links

- Feedback from the Think-Aloud: News link components take up significant space but lack clear relevance. The participants felt they were visually dominant but not compelling to click.
- **Suggestion***:* Simplify the layout or reposition these links under a more relevant section (such as Destructive Floods) with clearer context.

12. Little Etobicoke Example -> Problem -> Flood Models & Videos

- Flood modeling visuals for Little Etobicoke are placed under the “Problem” section, which may confuse users about whether the content describes issues or solutions.
- **Suggestion***:* Move these elements to the visualization/results section to better align with user expectations.

13. Examples -> Duplicated visualizations

- Some visualizations appear in both overview and visualization sections. For examples: The 10-, 350- years 4x1 Visualization for Little Etobicoke and the Before & After Reconstruction video for the Mouth of Don are used under both Overview and Visualization.
- This redundancy may lead users to assume differences where none exist.
- **Suggestion***:* Remove duplicates or clearly label them as repeated content for reference.

14. Examples -> references/external source linking

- External links and references use inconsistent formatting across pages, which might reduce the overall visual coherence.
- **Suggestion***:* Standardize formatting for all references and external links.

15. Examples -> Problem background

- The depth/length of content between Little Etobicoke and Mouth of Don River's problem background is uneven.
- During think-aloud, the participant felt they did not gain equal understanding of both cases due to the asymmetry in length coverage and storytelling.
- **Suggestion***:* Balance the level of detail across examples to provide a more consistent learning experience.

16. Team -> Navigation buttons

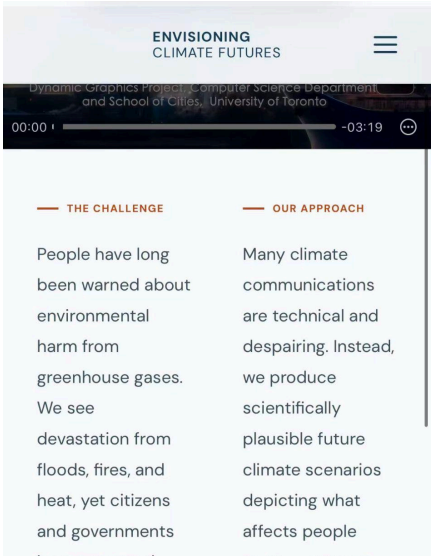
- Navigation buttons "Back" and "Methodology" are placed the end of the page, where the former leads to the Little Etobicoke Overview page and the later lead to the Methodology page.
- Unlike example pages, there is no clear flow or inherent order between these sections. Therefore, the connection here is slightly unintuitive and unnecessary.
- **Suggestion***:* Remove or redesign these buttons to better reflect meaningful navigation paths.

17. Footer -> Logos

- Logos of schools are highlighted on hover but are not clickable. The highlight may mislead users into expecting interaction.
- **Suggestion***:* Either make the logos clickable (e.g., link to institutions) or remove the hover effect to avoid confusion.

18. [Mobile Specific] Home -> Approach and Challenge

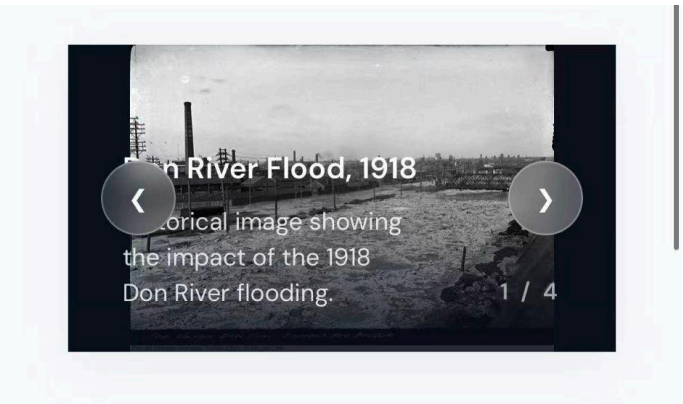
- The two-column layout for "Approach" and "Challenge" does not translate well to mobile.



- Users might need to scroll up and down repeatedly to read both sections, requiring additional actions that disrupt flow of reading.
- **Suggestion***:* Stack the sections vertically or redesign the layout for mobile to improve readability and continuity.

19. [Mobile Specific] Little Etobicoke Example -> Problem Destructive Floods

- Toggle buttons overlap and block a significant portion of the text and images, making the content difficult to read and interact with. No workaround for this is found.



- **Suggestion***:* Adjust the layout for mobile (e.g., reposition or collapse toggles) to ensure content remains fully visible and readable.